

Friday, 13 February 2026



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Coca-Cola Boosts Bushbuckridge Water Relief



Bushbuckridge — In a major boost to local water relief efforts.

Bushbuckridge — In a major boost to local water relief efforts, Coca-Cola Beverages South Africa (CCBSA), through its Bushbuckridge depot, has donated a 32 000-litre water tanker to the Bushbuckridge Local Municipality as part of a Public-Private Partnership initiative aimed at improving access to water services.

The donation comes at a critical time when many communities continue to face water shortages due to aging infrastructure, frequent breakdowns,

and the absence of reliable water systems in some areas.

“This water tanker will join the municipality’s existing fleet in supplying water to communities across all corners of the Bushbuckridge area.” The tanker will strengthen emergency water distribution and improve service delivery, particularly in rural villages and areas with limited or no reticulated water infrastructure.

On behalf of the municipality, the



Executive Mayor conveyed words of appreciation and gratitude to Coca-Cola for the donation, describing it as a meaningful and timely intervention that will assist the municipality in delivering one of the most essential services to residents.

The partnership reflects growing cooperation between the private sector and local government in addressing service delivery challenges, while long-term infrastructure development plans continue.



Important community notice:

Residents are reminded that water supplied by municipal tankers forms part of the Free Basic Water Service. Community members must not pay any money to anyone supplying water from municipal tankers. Any individual attempting to charge residents should be reported to the municipality.

The donation is expected to make an immediate impact in improving access to clean water and restoring dignity to communities affected by ongoing supply challenges.

CRIME

Rangers intercept suspected poachers in KNP



COMMUNITY

Humanitarian Aid Reaches Flood Victims



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SPIRITUAL REBIRTH

God With Us: The Power of Emmanuel In times of uncertainty, fear, or transition, the name Emmanuel offers profound reassurance. Meaning “God with us”, Emmanuel is not just a title but a promise — a declaration that we are never alone, no matter our circumstances.

First prophesied in Isaiah 7:14, the scripture says: “The virgin will conceive and give birth to a son, and will call him Emmanuel.” Centuries later, this prophecy was fulfilled in Matthew 1:23, as Jesus was born — the Word made flesh — living among humanity.

This name carries weight. It signifies that God is not distant or detached. He steps

into our world, our struggles, and our victories. Through Jesus, God chose to dwell with us — to comfort, guide, heal, and ultimately, to redeem.

For many, Emmanuel becomes a source of strength. It means God is present in the hospital ward, the courtroom, the classroom, and even the quiet places of prayer. His presence is constant, not seasonal.

As we journey through life’s changing seasons, the promise of Emmanuel remains unshaken. Whether in joy or sorrow, He is with us — not in theory, but in truth.

God with us. Always.

Bondzeni Celebrates 100% Pass Rate



Bondzeni Secondary School recorded a 100% matric pass rate in 2025, continuing a strong tradition of excellence.

There was jubilation, music and celebration at Bondzeni Secondary School in Kildare, within the Bushbuckridge Local Municipality, as education officials and community members gathered to honour the school’s outstanding academic achievement.

Bondzeni Secondary School recorded a 100% matric pass rate in 2025, continuing a strong tradition of excellence. The school previously achieved a 100% pass rate in 2022, delivered an exceptional performance in 2023, recorded a commendable 98% in 2024, and has now returned to full success in 2025.

The celebratory visit formed part of the Department’s ongoing commitment to promoting motivation, academic excellence and learner development. Senior departmental officials engaged with the Class of 2026, encouraging them to draw inspiration from the achievements of previous learners and to remain disciplined, focused and determined in their academic journey.

Officials emphasised that every learner has the potential to succeed when provided with the right support, guidance and encouragement, highlighting that



success is built through hard work, resilience and collective effort.

In recognition of the achievement, the Department presented tokens of appreciation to the school’s top 10 Grade 12 achievers. The gesture was aimed at inspiring current learners to aim higher, dream bigger and strive for academic excellence.

The Department reaffirmed its

commitment to supporting schools in their pursuit of excellence and ensuring that every learner is equipped with the skills, knowledge and confidence needed to succeed in a rapidly changing world.

Bondzeni Secondary School’s achievement stands as a powerful example of what is possible through dedication, teamwork and a shared vision for success.

CRIME

Rangers intercept suspected poachers in KNP



South African National Parks (SANParks) says its rangers have been involved in two recent anti-poaching incidents in the Kruger National Park, as authorities continue a sustained effort to disrupt rhino poaching and other wildlife crime.

According to SANParks, the first incident happened on Thursday, 5 February 2026, in the Malelane section of the park, where rangers came into contact with suspected poachers during patrol operations. No arrests were made at the time, but rangers recovered a high-calibre rifle and bags believed to be linked to poaching activity.

SANParks said the seizure of the weapon and equipment represents a meaningful disruption to criminal operations in the park, particularly at a time when rhino poaching remains one of the most persistent threats to conservation efforts.

A second contact was reported on Friday, 6 February 2026, in the Stolznek section of the park. SANParks said rangers engaged suspected poachers and one suspect was fatally wounded during the confrontation.

The incidents, SANParks said, reflect the dangers rangers face daily while protecting South Africa’s wildlife and natural heritage. The agency praised the commitment and bravery of ranger teams who continue to conduct patrols, track suspicious movement, and respond rapidly when threats are detected.

“The recovery of weapons and equipment demonstrates the effectiveness of ranger patrols and the commitment to safeguarding rhinos from relentless poaching threats,” SANParks said in a statement.

SANParks added that the fight against poaching remains a priority and that operations will continue to be intensified to protect rhinos for future generations.

Both incidents have been handed over to the South African Police Service (SAPS) for further investigation and processing.



The South African Red Cross Society has delivered critical humanitarian assistance to flood-affected communities in Bushbuckridge Local Municipality.

Humanitarian Aid Reaches Flood Victims

The South African Red Cross Society has delivered critical humanitarian assistance to flood-affected communities in Bushbuckridge Local Municipality, providing much-needed relief to families whose lives were disrupted by the devastating floods that struck parts of Mpumalanga last month.

On Wednesday, 12 February 2026, Red Cross teams distributed blankets, mattresses and food vouchers valued at R1,200 to vulnerable households across three villages within the municipality, bringing comfort and dignity to families still struggling to recover from the disaster. The final stop of the outreach programme was Marite village, where a number of severely affected families received support.

The intervention forms part of a broader relief programme made possible through funding support from Standard Bank. According to the Red Cross, the procurement of essential items – including blankets, mattresses and food vouchers – has been finalised, ensuring that communities in need receive timely and meaningful assistance.

“These essential items will be distributed

across three local municipalities this week to assist communities in need,” the organisation confirmed in a statement.

The floods, which hit parts of Mpumalanga last month, left many families displaced, homes damaged and livelihoods disrupted.

In Bushbuckridge, several villages experienced severe impact, with residents losing household goods, bedding and food supplies, leaving many in urgent need of humanitarian support.

Marite ward councillor cllr H Mokoena welcomed the intervention, describing it as a vital lifeline for struggling families.

“This support has come at the right time. Many families lost everything during the floods, and they are still trying to rebuild their lives. The blankets, mattresses and food vouchers will restore dignity and bring real relief to our community,” the councillor said.

The South African Red Cross Society extended its heartfelt appreciation to Standard Bank for its continued partnership and commitment to humanitarian relief efforts.



“We extend our sincere appreciation to Standard Bank for their continued support and commitment to humanitarian relief efforts. Together, we are able to bring comfort, dignity and hope to vulnerable families during this difficult time,” the organisation said.

Local leaders also praised the initiative, noting that partnerships between humanitarian organisations and the private sector play a critical role in responding to disasters and supporting communities during times of crisis.



The Red Cross further indicated that the current distribution forms part of ongoing relief efforts and that more support initiatives are expected in other affected areas as resources become available.

As Bushbuckridge communities continue the long road to recovery, the donation of essential supplies has brought renewed hope to families who have endured weeks of hardship, demonstrating the power of solidarity, compassion and coordinated humanitarian action in times of disaster.

Police Hunt Carjacking Suspects



The South African Police Service (SAPS) in Mpumalanga has launched a manhunt for three suspects following a violent carjacking incident in Bushbuckridge.

The crime took place on Friday evening, 6 February 2026, at around 21:30 in Mandela Village. According to police, the victim was driving a white Toyota Quantum when he arrived at his home and stopped at the gate to open it. As he returned to the vehicle, he was confronted by two unknown men, one of whom was armed with a firearm.

The armed suspect forced the complainant back into the vehicle, while the second suspect ordered him to lie down and stood on top of him while pointing the firearm at him. The suspects then drove off with the victim, later picking up a third suspect at an

unknown location.

After driving around for some time, the victim was dropped off at a nearby graveyard, where he was searched and robbed of a Samsung Galaxy A04 cellphone and R200 in cash. He was warned not to look back as the suspects fled the scene with the vehicle.

The stolen items are estimated to be worth approximately:

- Toyota Quantum: R500,000
- Samsung Galaxy A04 cellphone: R1,500

The suspects are described as three unknown men who were speaking different languages. At this stage, no arrests have been made, and investigations are ongoing.

The Acting Provincial Commissioner of SAPS in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, strongly condemned the incident and called on the community to assist police.

“Carjacking remains a serious and violent crime that poses a threat to the safety of our communities. We urge residents to work closely with the police by sharing any information that may assist in bringing the perpetrators to justice. Communities are reminded to remain vigilant and to prioritise their personal safety at all times,” he said.

Anyone with information that may assist the investigation is urged to contact Lieutenant Colonel Cindy Mkhabela on 082 469 1298, Crime Stop on 08600 10111, or report anonymously via the MySAPS App.

Police Killer Sentenced to 15 Years



A long-running investigation into the brutal killing of a Mpumalanga police officer has reached a major milestone, with one of the accused sentenced to 15 years’ imprisonment by the Mpumalanga High Court sitting in Middelburg.

The case relates to the orchestrated murder of Sergeant Joseph Kutu (43), a member of the Witbank Tactical Response Team, who was gunned down in July 2021 in Vosman, Emalahleni. Five years later, justice is beginning to take shape as the court finalises proceedings against those implicated in the carefully planned hit.

According to the Directorate for Priority Crime Investigation (the Hawks), Sgt Kutu had just returned from deployment when he arrived at his home and found that his wife, Patricia Kutu, was not there. She later returned and allegedly entered the house with two suspects, who then opened fire on the officer. Sgt Kutu was rushed to hospital but succumbed to his injuries shortly

afterwards.

The case was handed over to the Hawks’ Middelburg-based Serious Organised Crime Investigation unit. Their probe led to the arrest of two suspects and the recovery of two service firearms — a handgun and a rifle. Further investigations revealed a conspiracy to commit murder, leading to the arrest of Sgt Kutu’s wife as a co-accused.

All suspects were initially denied bail, although Patricia Kutu was later released on R10,000 bail following an appeal.

On 11 February 2026, Xolani Ndabezitha (29) pleaded guilty in the Mpumalanga High Court and was sentenced to 15 years’ imprisonment. One of his co-accused, Bonginkosi Langa, has also indicated his intention to plead guilty. His case was postponed to 18 February 2026. The matter involving Sgt Kutu’s wife is expected to

return to court on 17 January 2028.

Reacting to the sentencing, the Provincial Head of the Hawks in Mpumalanga, Major General Nico Gerber, said:

“One life lost is too many, let alone one of our own — a father and a well-trained member who served and protected the citizens of this country. We are pleased that one of the three is already sentenced and we strongly believe justice will be served for Sgt Kutu on the remaining two accused.”

The case has sent shockwaves through law enforcement circles and the community, highlighting both the dangers faced by police officers and the devastating impact of organised criminal violence.

As the remaining court processes continue, the Kutu family and the broader community await full closure in a case that has gripped Mpumalanga for nearly half a decade.

Rhino Poaching Drops 16%



South Africa recorded a 16% overall decline in rhino poaching in 2025 compared to the previous year, according to the Department of Forestry, Fisheries and the Environment.

The department attributed the positive trend to sustained collaboration between government, private rhino owners and non-governmental organisations, highlighting the importance of partnerships in protecting the country’s wildlife heritage.

Speaking on the progress, Aucamp said South Africa remains committed to an intelligence-driven and partnership-based approach to conservation, aimed at strengthening long-term rhino protection and disrupting wildlife trafficking networks.

The country’s efforts have also gained international recognition. South Africa recently received the Asia Environmental Enforcement Recognition of Excellence Award for its work in combating transboundary environmental crimes.

“South Africa continues to strengthen its international collaboration to curb rhino poaching and wildlife trafficking. These efforts led to the country receiving the Asia Environmental Enforcement Recognition of Excellence Award late last year, which celebrates excellence in enforcement by government officials, institutions and teams combating transboundary environmental crimes,” said Aucamp.

The department said it would continue to prioritise coordinated action and international cooperation to ensure the downward trend in rhino poaching is sustained.



Man Survives Shooting at Hazyview Café

A man survived a targeted shooting while having coffee at a restaurant near Perry’s Bridge in Hazyview on Monday 9 February 2026.

The victim, identified as Daniel Tehebo, an Ethiopian national, was reportedly followed by two armed men from another location before the attack. After parking his car and entering the restaurant, the suspects, driving a Volkswagen Polo, approached Tehebo and opened fire at close range.

Mpumalanga police spokesperson Lieutenant Colonel Jabu Ndubane said Tehebo was shot in the hand and stomach but was saved by swift action from security guards, who returned fire and forced the suspects to flee. Fifteen spent cartridges were recovered at the scene.

Tehebo was rushed to Nelspruit Mediclinic for urgent medical treatment. No members of the public were injured, and police continue to search for the suspects.



HAPPY
Valentine's
DAY

14 FEBRUARY 2026

“BushNews would like to wish you a joyful Valentine’s Day and thank you for being part of our community”

MEC Champions Social Relief and Community Programmes



12 February 2026 – Ehlanzeni District, Mpumalanga – The MEC for Social Development, Nompumelelo Hlophe, engaged with the Honourable MMCs today to emphasise the importance of championing government programmes aimed at supporting vulnerable communities.

During the meeting, MEC Hlophe highlighted Social Relief of Distress as a key initiative, providing essential support such as school uniforms to learners in need, ensuring they receive education with dignity.

She also reiterated the department’s commitment to addressing substance and drug abuse through ongoing provincial roadshows.

In addition, MEC Hlophe announced that the department will continue hosting the Golden Games, part of the Active Aging programme that encourages health and activity among older persons.

The MEC urged MMCs to exercise strong oversight over local SASSA and DSD offices, ensuring challenges are quickly escalated to her office for timely intervention. She emphasised that together, officials must serve as “a voice of hope and responsive leadership” in communities across the district.

MEC Hlophe’s engagement reflects the department’s focus on proactive community support and delivering tangible services to those most in need.



South Africa will not defeat gender-based violence and femicide (GBVF) unless families speak openly with their children and report abuse without fear, Justice and Constitutional Development Minister Mmamoloko Kubayi has warned.

Addressing residents at a Community Outreach Imbizo and Pre-State of the Nation Address (SONA) community activation at the Dulcie September Civic Hall in Athlone, Western Cape, Kubayi said incidents of sexual violence must never be hidden or treated as “private” matters.

“When something like this happens, we don’t sit on it and hide it. There cannot be a debate when there is rape... it is a crime,” she said.

Kubayi stressed that parents have both a legal and moral duty to report child sexual abuse, including teenage pregnancies involving minors.

She emphasised that a child cannot legally consent to sex and that pregnancy involving an underage child amounts to statutory rape.

“There is no 11-year-old who can give consent to sex. The age of consent is clear in the law. When a child becomes pregnant, it is statutory rape,” she said.

Families Must Speak Up On Abuse



The Minister urged families to act immediately by seeking medical care and reporting cases to the police. She added that teachers and community members share the same responsibility to protect children and report abuse.

Kubayi also raised concerns about cases where families conceal teenage pregnancies after accepting financial settlements from perpetrators. She warned that such deals protect offenders and expose other children to harm.

“You may spend that R50 000 and it will be finished, but you have a child who is destroyed for life. Once you do that, the perpetrator moves from this child to another,” she said.

Kubayi said perpetrators must be held accountable regardless of their status in a household, including if they are breadwinners. She added that abuse affects both girls and boys, calling on civil society and community activists to help fight what she described as a growing pandemic.

Government, she said, has amended legislation and is considering further reforms, including allowing the publication of convicted offenders’ names to prioritise victims over perpetrators.

Operation Shanela II Cracks Down on Crime



Operation Shanela II has delivered a major blow against crime in Mpumalanga, following a province-wide law-enforcement operation conducted between 5 and 8 February 2026.

The coordinated operation brought together multiple stakeholders, including the South African Police Service (SAPS), Traffic Police, various law-enforcement agencies, the Departments of Home Affairs, Health, Labour and Correctional Services, private security companies, and Community

Policing Forums (CPFs).

During the operation, law-enforcement teams carried out extensive activities across the province. A total of 275 premises were searched, while 4 285 people and 1 975 vehicles were stopped and searched. Police also conducted 1 106 stop-and-search operations, six specialised tracking operations, and 3 474 high-visibility patrols, which included 109 vehicle checkpoints, 26 roadblocks and 2 262 patrols. Detectives conducted 93 tracing operations for wanted suspects, and six hostels were searched.

Significant compliance and inspection operations were also undertaken. Six unlicensed liquor outlets were closed, while 282 licensed liquor outlets were inspected. Police inspected 91 second-hand dealers, issuing two notices for non-compliance, and visited 25 scrap yards and recyclers. Firearm compliance inspections were conducted at both non-official and official institutions, including private security companies and state facilities.

Labour-law compliance inspections were carried out at 132 informal businesses,

including spaza shops, and 22 formal businesses in the hospitality and retail sectors. Joint operations with the Departments of Home Affairs and Labour saw 78 farms and one mine inspected, while enforcement actions were also conducted in terms of the SASREA and Regulation of Gatherings Act.

Numerous arrests were made during the operation, including wanted suspects linked to serious crimes such as murder, rape, carjacking, assault GBH and illegal possession of firearms. Additional arrests were recorded for a wide range of offences, including drug dealing and possession, illegal liquor trading, possession of dangerous weapons, firearm and ammunition offences, serious violent crimes, burglary, driving under the influence, and human trafficking. A total of 70 illegal immigrants were also arrested.

Large quantities of illegal items were confiscated, including drugs, firearms, ammunition, dangerous weapons, alcohol, copper cables, cash, contraband goods and vehicles. Drug seizures included dagga, crack cocaine, crystal meth (tik), nyaope, mandrax tablets and mandrax powder.

Acting Provincial Commissioner of SAPS in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, praised all law-enforcement agencies and stakeholders for the successful execution of the operation.

He said the sustained, integrated approach demonstrated SAPS’ unwavering commitment to decisively combat crime and restore safety and order across Mpumalanga.

Operation Shanela II is expected to continue strengthening visible policing, community safety and coordinated crime prevention efforts throughout the province.

Man Arrested for Unlicensed Firearm



Ernest Railu (36) appeared at Mbitane Magistrate’s Court on Tuesday, 10 February 2026, facing charges of possession of an unlicensed firearm and ammunition.

Railu was arrested in the early hours of Monday, 09 February, around 00:30, in the Vaalbank policing area. Police conducting routine patrols stopped a suspicious red vehicle with a Mpumalanga registration

number plate.

One passenger fled with a black handbag but was quickly apprehended. A search of the bag revealed a black revolver with no serial number and nine rounds of live ammunition. Railu could not produce a valid firearm licence, and the items were confiscated as exhibits.

The recovered firearm will undergo forensic ballistic testing to determine whether it has been used in other crimes. Railu remains in custody and will appear again on 17 February for a formal bail application.

Acting Provincial Commissioner of Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, commended police for their vigilance, saying the confiscation was “a significant step towards preventing potential violent crimes.”



Fatal Pitbull Attack Under Police Investigation



Waterval Boven police are investigating the death of a man who was attacked by pit bulls in the early hours of Tuesday, 11 February 2026.

According to authorities, the incident occurred around 02:00 when the man, who was reportedly living with mental health challenges, was passing a scrapyard. Two pit bulls and three other dogs belonging to the scrapyard owner allegedly escaped and attacked him.



Police and Emergency Medical Services

arrived at the scene at approximately 05:10 and found the man’s lifeless body on the road next to the scrapyard. The pit bulls were reportedly seen with blood on their mouths. The victim was later identified by his family.

Acting Provincial Commissioner of SAPS in Mpumalanga, Major General (Dr) Zeph Mkhwanazi, expressed his deepest condolences to the family and reminded dog owners of the importance of securing animals to prevent such tragedies.

Investigations into the attack are ongoing.

CAFAMens League Kicks Off With Exciting Fixtures



The CAFA Men's League returned with a bang on Saturday, marking the start of the 2026 season in Acornhoek.

In Mapaleng, Acornhoek Ajax FC and Moholoholo Academy FC shared the spoils in a thrilling 1-1 draw at the Score Rangers Sport Ground. Both sides showed strong attacking intent, keeping fans on the edge of their seats until the final whistle.

Meanwhile, in a fiercely contested local derby at the Acornhoek Police Station Ground, Acornhoek Arsenal FC suffered a heavy 6-1 defeat to Acornhoek City FC. The match saw City FC dominate from start to finish, delighting supporters with an impressive display of skill and teamwork.

The league promises more action-packed games as teams battle for early-season supremacy in the CAFAMensLeague.



**Kruger
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